

The long road back

Xiaomi and the reinvention of the Redmi Note

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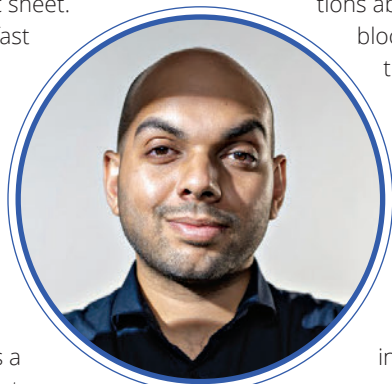
For a long time, recommending a smartphone to a friend, family member, or reader was a relatively straightforward task that rarely required more than a quick look at the spec sheet. If the processor was fast enough, the battery large enough, and the screen sharp enough, you could point someone to a specific phone with confidence and move on to the next thing. In that era, performance was a measurable metric that lived and died by benchmarks. And for most of the last decade, the Redmi Note was the default recommendation. It sat in the middle of the Indian smartphone market and offered more hardware than people expected for the money. You bought it because it made sense. Most reviewers, including yours truly recommended it because there was little downside. But markets changed, and so did habits.

The long tail of ownership

Phones became good enough that people no longer upgrade every year. Prices climbed. Memory costs rose. And the mid-premium segment, once driven by aggressive specs, is now shaped by longevity and reliability.

The Note remained popular, but its purpose grew less obvious. So, when it came to the Redmi Note 15 Pro series this year, Xiaomi, by its own admission, revisited some long-held assumptions about how to build a

blockbuster device for the Indian consumer.



Sandeep Sarma
Associate Director,
Marketing & PR,
Xiaomi India

According to Sandeep Sarma, Assistant Director, Marketing and PR at Xiaomi India, the shift began with an uncomfortable realisation inside Xiaomi. “We were looking at the Note portfolio from a Pro Plus to vanilla Note perspective,” he says. “We said we’ll give the Pro Plus everything, and then see

where we water things down to arrive at a cost price. And I think that was probably the wrong approach.” This “trickle-down” method often left the base models feeling like compromised versions of a flagships.

Instead of starting at the top and scaling downward, Xiaomi flipped the logic. It asked what a good Note should be now, in a market where people were no longer switching phones every year.

“In 2017, the average upgrade cycle was nine months to a year,” Sarma says. “Now people are holding on to their devices for two and a half, three

and a half years. For the Note series, we’re seeing five, five and a half years.”

Xiaomi’s own data shows many Note 15 buyers upgrading from Note 8, 9, or 10 models, and not last year’s phone. That changes everything. If a phone is expected to live longer, short-term spec wins matter less than durability, service, and software support that holds up after novelty fades.

Value, after the spec race

Xiaomi built its reputation on value, but Sarma is clear that value no longer means what it did five years ago. Back then, a higher megapixel count or a faster processor was often enough to justify an upgrade. Today, those markers feel abstract.

“People are going beyond specs,” he says. “The markers turn out to be software support, after-sales support, durability, and longevity.”

And this is why Xiaomi decided to extend the software support on the Note 15 Pro series to four years of Android updates and six years of security patches.

“We can keep rolling out software updates,” Sarma says. “But if your hardware does not support it, the chipset that you’re using, then it doesn’t matter. So it should not be that the update rolls out four years later but the device itself isn’t working. So we’re figuring out how to make sure, from a hardware and software perspective, there is still longevity.”

Throughout the conversation, Sarma returns to one idea: being easy to recommend.

“The Note series was traditionally the easiest smartphone to recommend in India,” he says. “I think we probably stayed away from that path for a bit. Now we’re back.”

Sarma indicates that internally, Xiaomi has shifted focus away from volume metrics toward trust. **d**

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